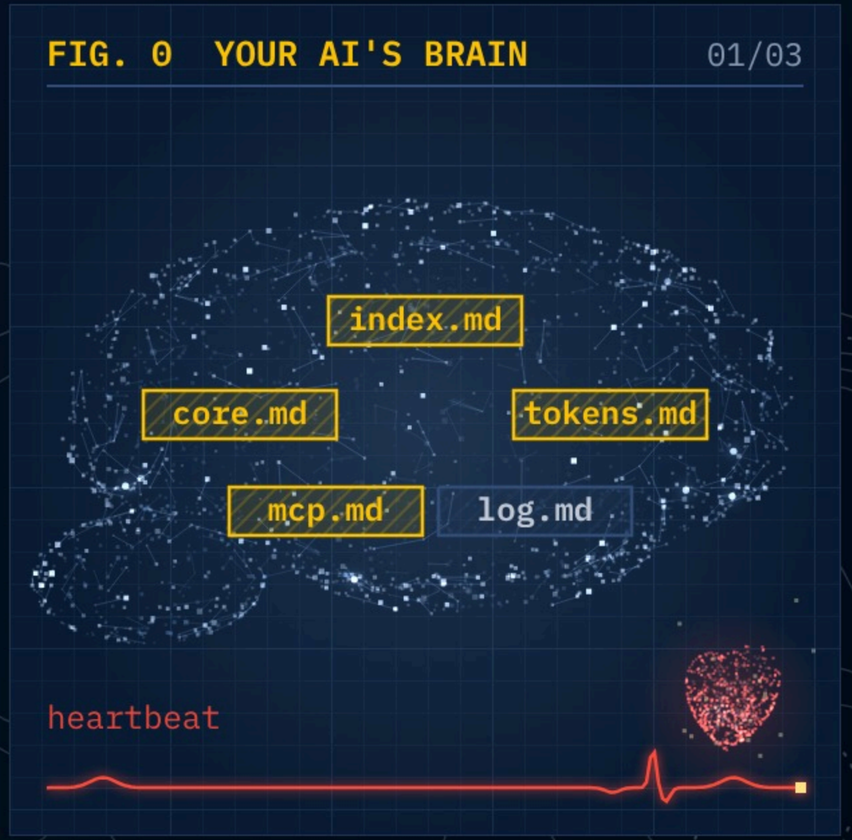
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THE MEMORY LAYER · PART 1

Why your AI needs a brain

The model forgets every session. Give it memory you own: plain files, linked, and readable by any AI.



15–minute video

All roles

Any harness · any model

JOSH

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TODAY

By the end, your learners can…

1
Explain why a model forgets and where memory can live

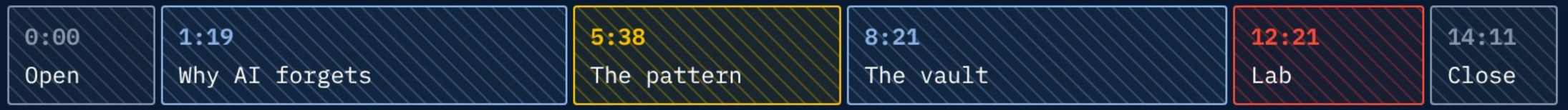
2
Describe the LLM Wiki pattern: raw, wiki, index, log and the schema

3
Walk a vault: memory layers, the heartbeat and the recall ladder

4
Point any AI at a brain and get answers with citations

CHAPTERS · 15-MIN VIDEO

drawn to scale



ALEX

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WHY THIS MATTERS

Your AI is brilliant and has no memory

01

Every session starts empty

The context window is working memory. Close the chat and it is gone.

02

Built-in memory isn't yours

Vendor memory lives in one product. You can't read it, audit it or take it with you.

03

Knowledge is scattered

Guides, transcripts and decisions sit in folders nobody re-reads, so the AI can't either.

Today's question:

How do we give any AI a memory we own and can check?

ALEX

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BLOCK 1 · WHY AI FORGETS

The model forgets. The files don’t.

> Memory isn’t a model feature you wait for. It’s files you control.

Context window = working memory

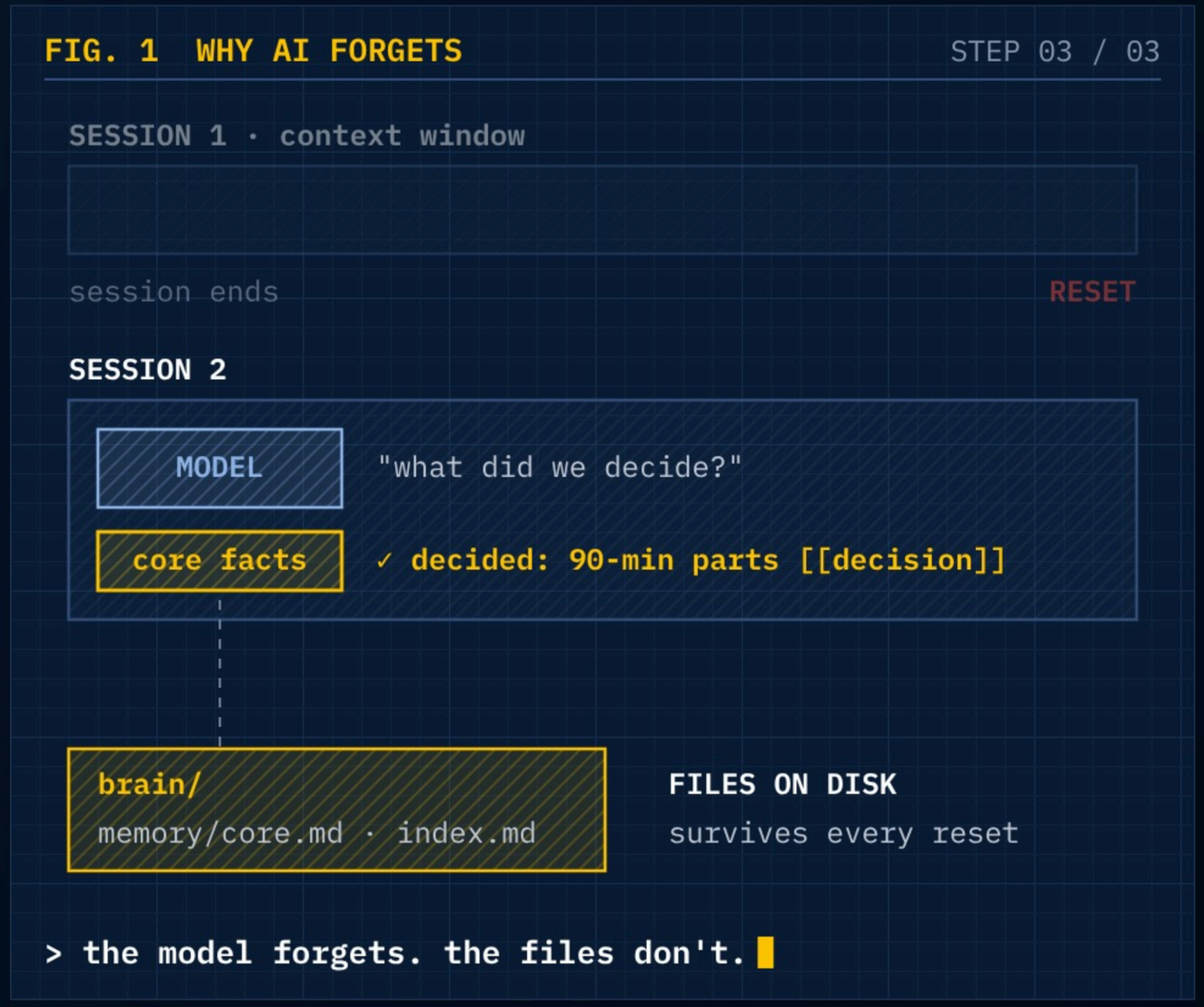
A fixed token budget that empties when the session ends

No files, no recall

Ask about last week and the model can only guess or say it doesn’t know

Files = memory that survives

Load the right few files at the start and the answer comes back, with a source



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BLOCK 1 · HOW A BRAIN REMEMBERS

Your own brain already solved this

FIG. 2 HOW A BRAIN REMEMBERS

STEP 03 / 03 · RECALL

EXPERIENCE IN

note

decision

transcript



QUESTION IN

cue:
what did we decide?

✓ 90-min parts

SLEEP · REPLAY
hippocampus -> cortex

> encode fast. replay to keep. recall by cue.

Hippocampus
→ working memory (fast)

Sleep replay
→ the scheduled heartbeat

Neocortex
→ wiki pages (lasting)

Recall by cue
→ a query with citations

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BLOCK 1 · THREE HOMES FOR MEMORY

Where can an AI's memory live?

Built-in product memory	
You can read it	PARTLY
Works in any tool	NO
Shows graphics	NO
Setup	NONE

Best for personal preferences inside one app.

Vector database (RAG)	
You can read it	NO
Works in any tool	WITH CODE
Shows graphics	NO
Setup	PIPELINE

Best for millions of documents and search at scale.

Markdown + HTML views	
You can read it	YES
Works in any tool	YES
Shows graphics	VIA HTML
Setup	A FOLDER

Best for a person's or team's high-signal knowledge.

NEW · MAY 2026 For anything people **read**, render **HTML** (diagrams, tables, tabs). For what the AI **recalls**, keep **markdown**.

BLOCK 2 · THE LLM WIKI PATTERN

Read once, file everywhere

> Sources go in once. The AI spreads what they teach across linked pages.

raw/ holds the sources

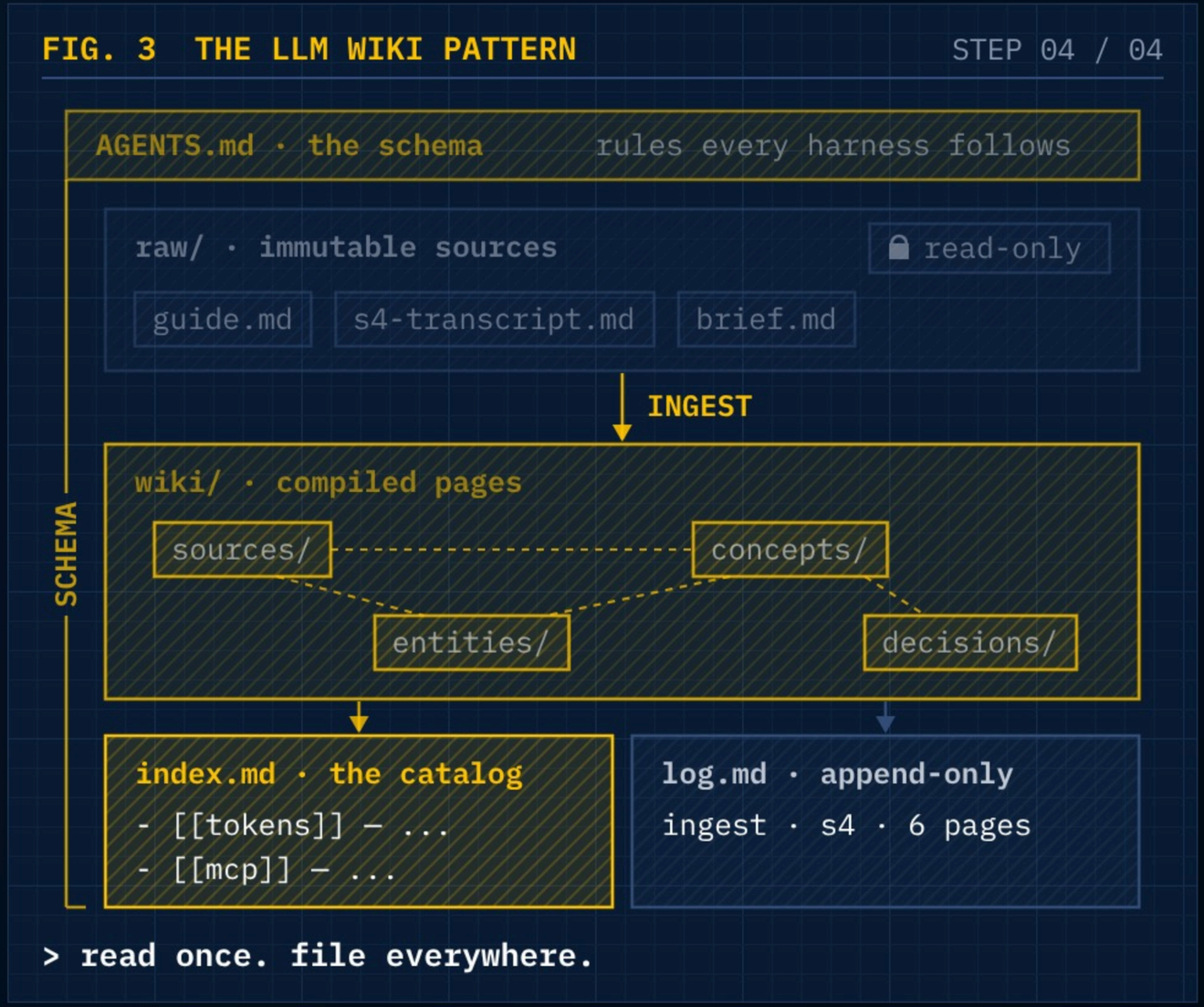
Guides, transcripts, clipped articles. The AI reads them and never edits them

wiki/ holds the pages

Sources, concepts, entities and decisions the AI writes and links

index.md, log.md, AGENTS.md

The catalog, the audit trail, and the rules every harness follows



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BLOCK 2 · THREE OPERATIONS

Knowledge compounds

> Every good answer is saved back, so the next time it's a single read.

Ingest

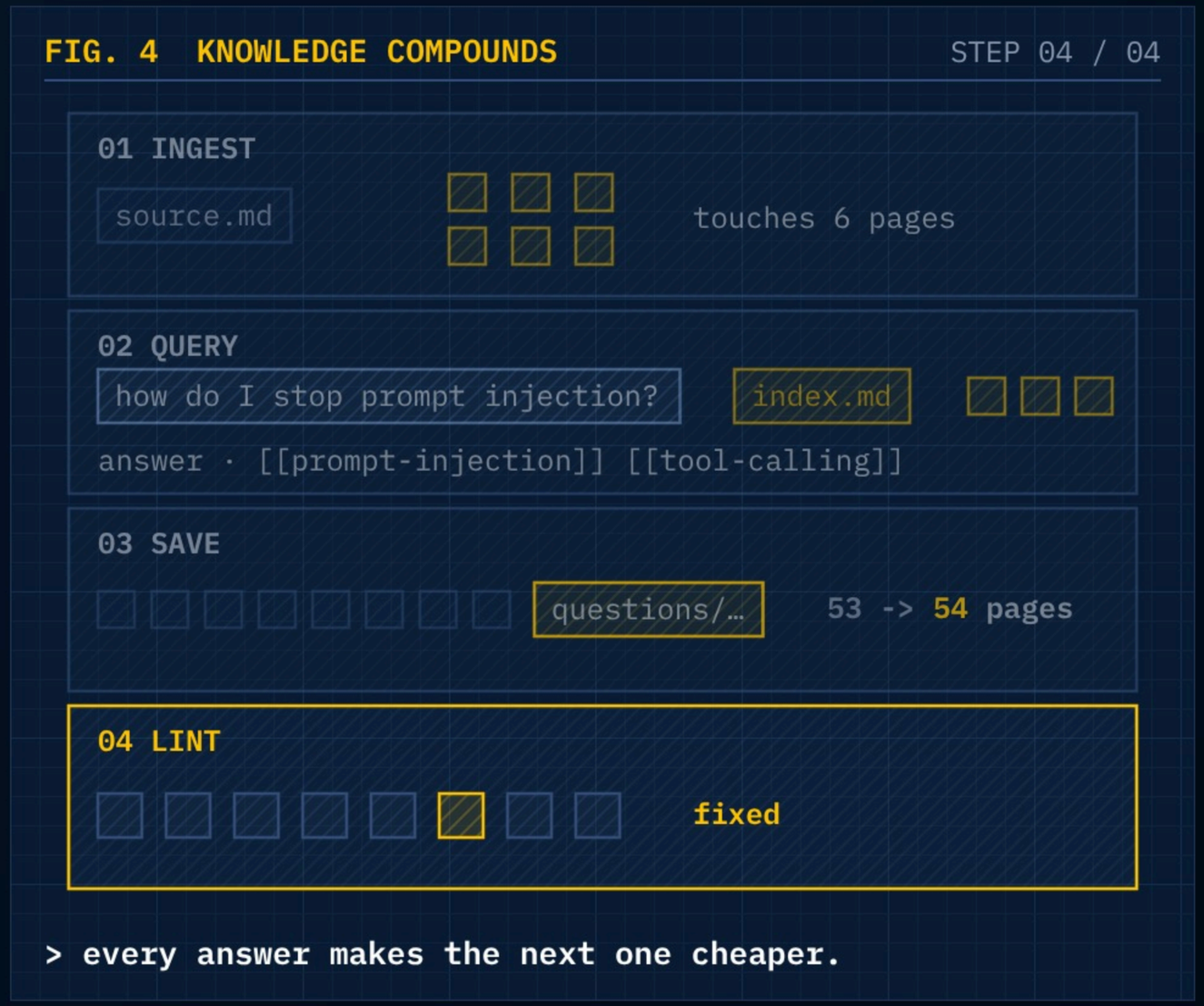
One source updates 3 to 10 pages, the index and the log

Query

Index first, a few pages, an answer with [[citations]]; good answers are saved as pages

Lint

Broken links, orphans, stale claims and contradictions, found and fixed



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WALKTHROUGH

Watch one source spread through the brain

Watch

1	**Drop a source**	Put a new document into inbox/ and ask: “ingest this.”
2	**Watch it spread**	One source page, several concept pages updated, index.md and log.md changed.
3	**Ask across sources**	“How do tokens relate to the recall ladder?” The answer cites pages from two sessions.
4	**Review the change**	git diff shows every edit. Nothing is hidden inside a model.

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BLOCK 3 · INSIDE THE VAULT

Four layers of memory

> Only the small top layers cost tokens in every session.

Core and working: always loaded

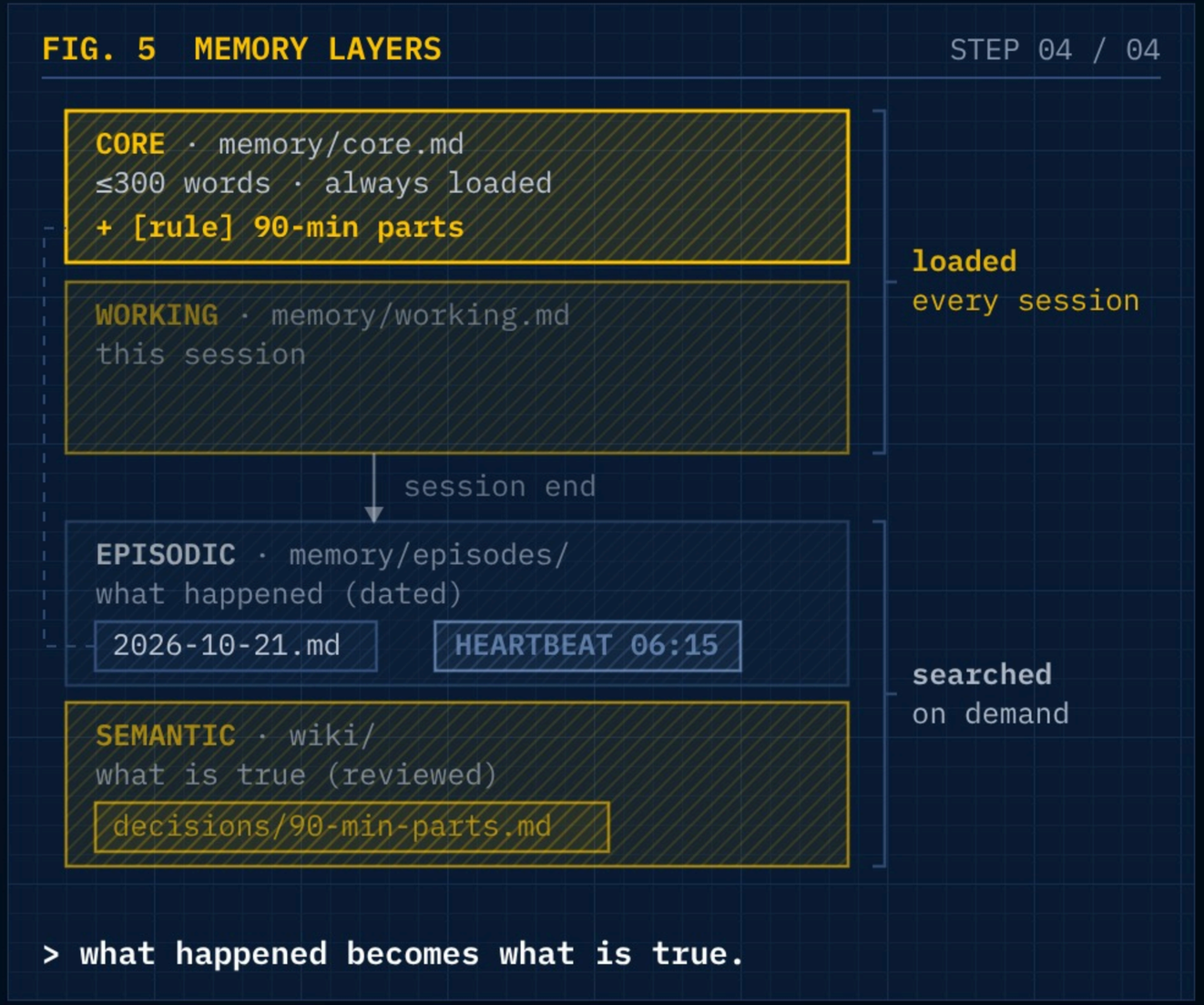
A few hundred words of standing facts, plus this session's notes

Episodic: what happened

Dated archives of each session's working notes

Semantic: what is true

Reviewed wiki pages; a scheduled heartbeat promotes facts into them



BLOCK 3 · THE HEARTBEAT

The brain tidies itself while you sleep

> One scheduled command keeps the brain clean, with no one remembering to.

A scheduled job

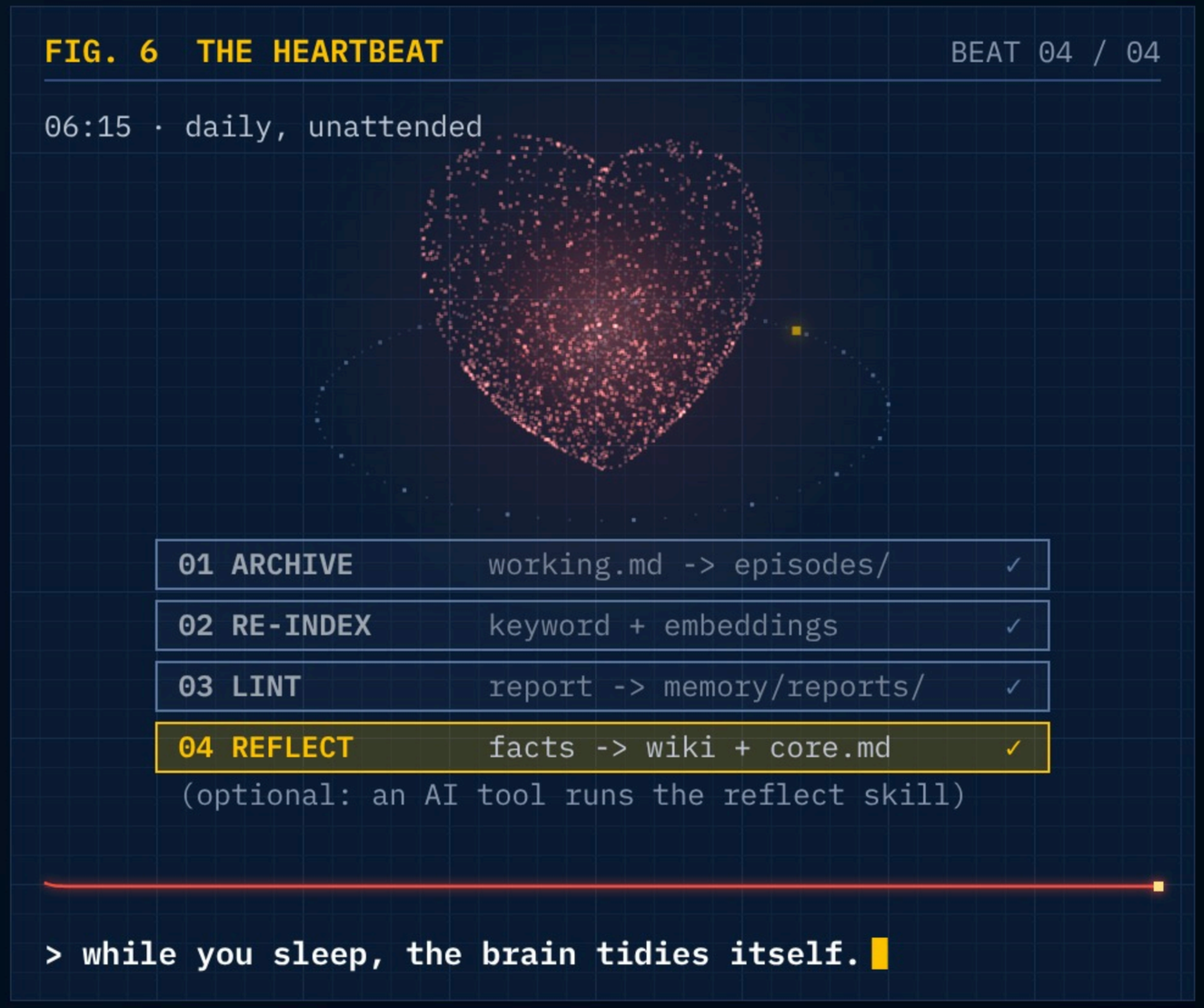
Runs on its own, daily or weekly, when nobody is working in the vault

Archive, re-index, lint

Files the session notes, refreshes search, writes a health report

Reflect (optional)

An AI tool promotes facts to the wiki and core.md, and flags the rest



BLOCK 3 · THE RECALL LADDER

Cheapest recall first

> Every rung costs more tokens. Stop when you have enough.

Core, then the index

Most questions stop at rung 2: scan summaries, open one page

Search when the index isn't enough

Keyword plus local semantic search, then follow the links

raw/ only for exact wording

The biggest token bill; open a source only to quote it



BLOCK 3 · PORTABILITY

One brain, any harness

> The model is rented. The brain is yours.

AGENTS.md is the manual

Folder map, page rules, the recall ladder and the safety rules, in one file

Each tool finds it its own way

Most read AGENTS.md directly; others import it from their own instruction file

Swap the model, keep the brain

Session 2's resilience, applied to knowledge



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THE RULE OF THUMB

Memory lives in **files**, not in the model. Read the **index** first. Raw last. Every answer **cites** a page.

If you can’t open the page it came from, it isn’t memory. It’s a guess.

ALEX

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HANDS-ON LAB 1

Same questions, with and without a brain

Pause & try

A	**Baseline**	In any AI tool with no files attached, ask the three lab questions. Note what it says.
B	**With the brain**	Start the tool inside brain-vault/. Ask the same three. Open every [[citation]] it gives.
C	**Feed it**	Drop the lab note into inbox/, ask it to ingest, then ask question 3 again. Read log.md.
D	**Debrief**	Which answers changed? Which citations held up? What did the index save you?

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CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING

Can every learner answer these?

1

Why doesn't a bigger context window give a model memory?

2

Name one strength and one limit of a vector database compared with a markdown brain.

3

What do raw/, wiki/, index.md and log.md each hold?

4

What does the heartbeat do overnight, and what will it never touch?

5

A question can be answered from index.md. Why not search raw/ anyway?

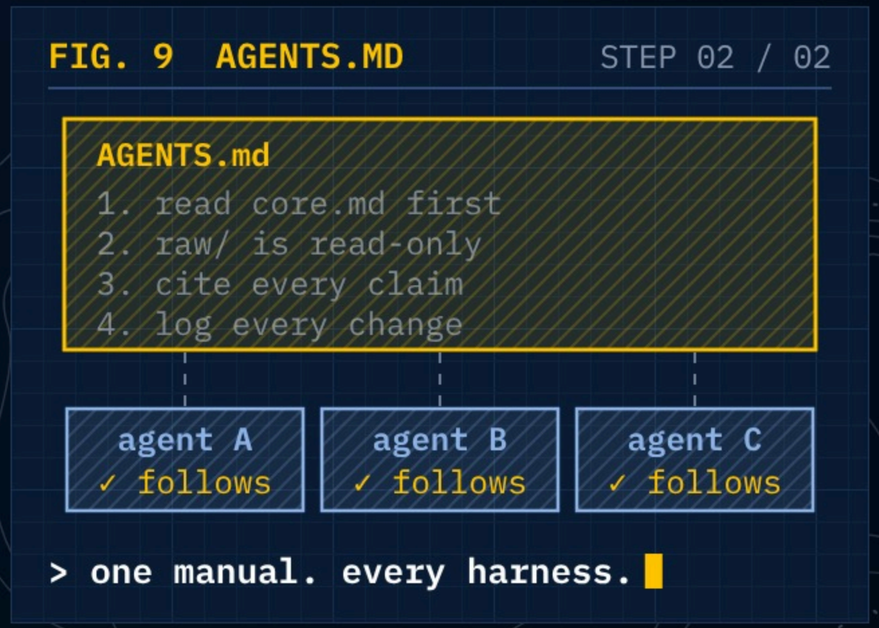
6

You switch to a different AI tool. What has to change in the brain?

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NEXT · PART 2 · THE OPERATING MANUAL

What makes every AI behave the same way in your brain?



What Part 2 covers

- AGENTS.md, the schema
- Page rules and templates
- Skills for each operation
- One brain, every harness

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THE MEMORY LAYER · PART 1 · WRAP-UP

Memory you own, for any AI

FIG. 10 THE BRAIN YOU BUILT

WIKI PAGES 55 / 55

+ guide
+ 10 transcripts
+ 3 briefs



core.md · always loaded
index.md · read first
wiki/ · 55 linked pages

> memory you own. any AI, every session.

Today's reference brain: **14 sources** compiled into **55 linked pages**, readable by any AI tool.

JOSH